A Brief Account of the Life of Diwan Bahadur Rettaimalai Srinivasan

***Jeeviya Charithira Surukkam* (ஜீவிய சரித்திர சுருக்கம்), by Rettaimalai Srinivasan (1860–1945)**

English translation from the Tamil

Translated by Neelam P.J. Pradeep Jesudas · மொழிபெயர்ப்பு: நீலம் பி.ஜே.பிரதீப் ஜேசுதாஸ்
First edition, October 2026. This edition has not yet been checked against a printed copy of the 1939 original.

Translator's Introduction

The author. Rettaimalai Srinivasan (7 July 1860 – 18 September 1945) was one of the founders of the modern Dalit movement in South India. He was born near Madurantakam in Chengalpattu district and studied at the college in Coimbatore. For about ten years he worked as an accountant for European firms in the Nilgiris. He then came to Madras and in 1891 joined, and soon ran, the Paraiyar Mahajana Sabha. In October 1893 he founded the journal *Paraiyan*, which he ran for about seven years. In 1900 he set out for London to put his community's case before the British public. He fell ill on the way, stayed in Zanzibar, and then lived for many years in Natal, South Africa, where he worked for the government and came to know M. K. Gandhi. He returned to India in 1921 and was nominated to the Madras Legislative Council in 1923. He represented the Depressed Classes with Dr B. R. Ambedkar at the Round Table Conferences in London (1930–32) and was a signatory of the Poona Pact (1932). The government gave him the titles Rao Sahib (1926), Rao Bahadur (1930) and Diwan Bahadur (1936). He was Ambedkar's elder colleague, and he was related by marriage to Pandit C. Iyothee Thass.

The book. *Jeeviya Charithira Surukkam* ("A Brief History of [My] Life") is a short autobiography, published by the author himself in Madras in 1939. The internal evidence agrees with that date. He refers to the Corporation election of "the past November 1938". He says the M. C. Rajah bill was passing "as this history goes to press", and that bill was enacted in 1938–39. He also says he now sits in the Legislative Council. Rather than tell his life year by year, he organises it by theme: his journal, his journey abroad, the "community", the petition against simultaneous Civil Service examinations, the Labour Commissioner, education, his work in the Legislature, the Round Table Conference, the Poona Pact, temple entry, conversion, the Indian National Congress, Gandhi, his family life, and a conclusion. The original edition had appendices of documents: (1) the 1893 counter-petition on the Civil Service examination, (2) a Government Order on the use of public roads and wells, and (3) the Poona Pact.

Public-domain status. The author died on 18 September 1945. Under the Indian Copyright Act, 1957 (life + 60 years), his works entered the public domain on 1 January 2006. The original Tamil text is therefore free to translate. This English translation is a new work.

Source text used. I could not find the 1939 first edition online; it is not on Tamil Digital Library, Internet Archive, Google Books or HathiTrust as far as I could search. The text I translated is the 1999 reprint by **Dalit Sahitya Akademi, Chennai**. That edition was set from the copy of the original held in the library of the **French Institute of Pondicherry**, with some damaged pages supplied by V. Alex (Madurai). The publishers state that they present the book "in the same manner in which he published it in his lifetime". The reprint adds one piece of editorial matter: a publisher's preface (*Pathippurai*, December 1999), a biographical note by the publishers. I have **not** translated it, because it is a modern text and not by Srinivasan. One editorial bracket in the body, "[a line is damaged in the original copy]", also comes from the reprint and I have kept it.

The reprint's Tamil text was transcribed online by Malarvizhi (credited as "Thozhar Malarvizhi") in two places: - https://ayyothidhasapandithar.blogspot.com/2011/08/blog-post_22.html (posted 22 Aug 2011): the front matter and the first chapters; - the *Writing Caste* blog, http://writingcaste.wordpress.com/ (posts dated Aug 2011 – Aug 2013, "The brief autobiography of Rettaimalai Srinivasan – Part 1 … Part 15"), which I read through Internet Archive (Wayback Machine) captures. The posts give the Tamil text together with an English rendering.

I translated directly and independently from the Tamil. Where the *Writing Caste* English differs from the Tamil, I followed the Tamil.

Completeness. - **Translated in full:** everything by Srinivasan that survives online in Tamil. That is the title-page matter, the author's preface (*Mukavurai*), the "Government's Opinion" (the Collector's speech of 1926), the whole main narrative from the opening to the end of the chapter "My Family Life", and the Conclusion (*Mudivurai*). - **Not translated:** the three appendices (*Anubandham* 1–3), because I could not find their Tamil text online. *Writing Caste* gives them only in English (Part 15, which is itself cut off in the archived copy). Two of them were probably English-language documents in the original as well (a petition to the British Parliament, and the Poona Pact). The opening words of the narrative are lost: the 1999 editors note that a line is damaged.

Conventions. Square brackets [ ] mark my additions for clarity. **[?]** marks a reading I am unsure of, and each one is explained in a translator's note (TN). I have kept the author's community terms as he used them: Paraiyar, Adi Dravida, Panchama, "the depressed", "untouchables", "caste Hindus". When he writes "this community" or "our people", he means the Paraiyar / Adi Dravidar. Dates and figures are given as in the Tamil, even where they seem inconsistent; I point out the inconsistencies in the notes.

A Brief History of the Life of Diwan Bahadur Rettaimalai Srinivasan

Preface (*Mukavurai*)

Out of many thousands of years, in the very short span of fifty years, the community now called the Adi Dravidas has made progress, and I have seen that progress in my own life-history. It is my aim that this history, too, should be added to the history of the Adi Dravida community.

This history will also make clear two things. First, that what other communities and other religions have done in the name of seeking this community's advancement has been self-seeking. Second, that this community has been rising through its own unceasing effort.

[Title-page matter]

A Brief History of the Life of Diwan Bahadur Rettaimalai Srinivasan

Recorded here, very briefly, is the life-history of fifty years of labour for the advancement of the Adi Dravidas, carried on with the support of the Government.

Rao Sahib Rettaimalai Srinivasan "He has been a sage, a guide and a friend to his community, and has won their esteem." — *The Collector of Chengalpattu*

The Government's Opinion

On Saturday, 20 February 1926, at the Darbar held at Saidapet, His Excellency the Viceroy and Governor-General of India conferred on Mr. Rettaimalai Srinivasan the title of Rao Sahib and its insignia. On that occasion the Collector of Chengalpattu, the Honourable P. Seetharamaiah Pantulu Garu, M.A., spoke as follows:

"The next person fortunate enough to receive an honour is Mr. Rettaimalai Srinivasan, at present residing at Poonamallee. He is now an elder of sixty-five, advanced in years, and a champion who toils for the Adi Dravidas. He was educated at the college in Coimbatore and acquired special skill in accounts and administration. His chief principle has been to serve, as far as he can, the community in which he was born. In 1891 he entered public service and established the (Paraiyar Mahajana Sabha) Adi Dravida Mahajana Sabha of Madras. In 1893 he began to publish a journal called *Paraiyan*. His aim was to raise his caste-people, who for many generations had been subjected to many hardships because of that despised name, 'Paraiyan'.

"On 23 December 1893 he convened a great meeting in the Wesleyan Mission hall at Royapettah, so that his people might be awakened and rise up. On 23 October 1895 a large meeting, such as these people had never before held, assembled in the Town Hall. Thirty-two years ago, Mr. Srinivasan was the first to give to the Adi Dravidas, who had been silent (without the strength to understand their rights, argue for them and win them), the awakening (to understand their rights and to voice them). This scattered class was brought together and, like the other castes, attained the standing of a distinct class in the Indian nation. 6 December 1895 is a special day, never to be forgotten. On that day he led a deputation of the Adi Dravidas before His Excellency Lord Elgin, then Viceroy and Governor-General of India. In 1896, when His Excellency Lord Wenlock, Governor of Madras, was leaving for England, he read and presented to him a farewell address on behalf of the Adi Dravidas.

"The journal *Paraiyan* continued until Mr. Srinivasan went to England in 1900. Afterwards he went to South Africa and took employment under the Union Government in 1904. After sixteen years of faithful service, and two years in East Africa, he retired, and in 1921 he returned to his native India. He believes that his people will not advance until they cultivate virtues such as self-reliance, abstinence from drink and moderate spending. He has studied and understood that if the Adi

Dravidas are not loyal to the Crown, they will lose the sympathy of the officers who govern them. To his community living in South Africa and in South India he has been a sage, a guide and a friend, and he has won their esteem.

“Two years after returning to his motherland, he became a member of the Madras Legislative Council, and he has been working there with the utmost care and attention for the good of the Adi Dravidas. For about thirty-five years he has laboured with unflagging energy and zeal for the advancement of the community in which he was born, and he has now reached old age. As the fruit of this quiet, unadvertised service, he has won the goodwill and respect of his class. Because of his good quality of not engaging in communal agitations, public workers of other communities also honour him. He was the first to arise and work among the thousands of people who lie helpless and in distress in our Presidency, and in recognition of this benefaction the Government are pleased to confer on him the title of Rao Sahib. Wishing that he may long continue to work among the public, I offer him my good wishes, and I present to him with all my heart the title of Rao Sahib and its insignia, conferred by His Excellency the Viceroy and Governor-General of India.”

> **TN 1.** The Collector’s dates differ from the author’s own: “23 October 1895, Town Hall” here, against “7 October 1895, Victoria Hall” below. The Victoria Public Hall in Madras was the “Town Hall”. The Collector says Srinivasan went to South Africa and took service in 1904. The author’s own account (below) has him spend two years in Zanzibar first. The author also says the Rao Sahib title was conferred on 1 January 1926 (the New Year Honours), while the Darbar at which the insignia were presented was on 20 February 1926. I have translated both as they stand.

A Brief History of [My] Life

[*A line is damaged in the original copy.*] … my elders used to say that in the time of … [our family] came from Thanjavur to the city of Madras for the sake of trade.

I was born in 1860 in one of the villages of Chengalpattu. When I studied at the college in Coimbatore, of about 400 pupils all but ten were Brahmins. The rules of caste were observed very strictly. I was afraid that if I made friends with the boys and they came to know my caste, family, dwelling and so on, they would treat me as low. So I would sit reading somewhere outside the school, and go into the class only after the opening bell had rung. When the class broke up, I would walk home quickly so that the other students could not catch up with me. I grieved over the cruelty of not being allowed to mix and play with the other boys. Brooding on it again and again, I used to think how this oppression could be overcome. After I qualified in accountancy I worked as an accountant in European business houses in the hill country called the Nilgiris. For all those ten years, the worry of how untouchability could be abolished never left me.

In 1890 I came to Madras. For three years I carried out many investigations into how those called “Paraiyar” could be raised to a higher position like the other castes, and made to be respected. I travelled south, by rail and mostly on foot. I saw: - at Kumbakonam, the ruined fort-wall of Nandan; [the sites associated with] Nandan of the leather coin [?], and Nandan who sang the *Kalambakam*; - the magnet-fort [?] built by the Kammalar, which was destroyed by a Sambava princess; - the tank-bank of the Umai clan [?], where Nandanar, called Thirunalaippovar, stood and worshipped, and the *matam* (religious house) beside it; - the shrines built at the places where

Sambava Samban of Tiruchirappalli, Praviyadai Samban, Periyanayaki and Mariyammai of Thanjavur, Thiyaga Samban of Tiruvarur and others were cremated; - the samadhi of the Great Paraiyan who rode an elephant, and the rights his descendants hold in the Thiyaga Samban temple at Tiruvarur. I stayed one night in their quarter and made enquiries.

Then, going near many temples, I met the people of this community in each place. I came to understand the sorrow they suffer. They have no water to bathe in or to drink, no secure hut to live in, no path to walk on, no means of livelihood. Wherever they go they are subjected to the cruelty called untouchability, and they are beaten if they open their mouths to speak. The officials who hear their grievances act deceitfully, out of fear of the caste Hindus. They endure suffering that cannot be borne. Having understood this, and having also enquired into their ancient history, I returned.

> **TN 2.** This paragraph is a list of sites that Srinivasan, like Iyothee Thass, took as evidence of the Paraiyars' ancient status: the Nandan legends, and temples he believed were built over the cremation-places of Paraiya ("Samban/Sambava") ancestors (compare the chapter "Temple Entry" below). Several names are obscure to me. These are "தோல்காசு நந்தன்" (Nandan of the leather coin [?]), "காந்த கோட்டை" (magnet-fort [?]), "ஊமைகுலக் கரை" (the bank of the Umai clan [?]; perhaps a tank), "பிரவியடை சாம்பான்" (probably the same as "Praviyadai/Pravidai Samban", whom he links to Brihadisvara at Thanjavur), and "யானையேரும் பெரும்பறையன்" (the Great Paraiyan who mounts an elephant). I have translated them literally.

When I examined the Government records, I found that from the year 1772 the Government had shown concern for this community. In 1818 the Board of Revenue asked the Collectors to report on ways and means for the advancement of the cultivators of this community. What became of that is not known. In 1893 they set about providing education. For 120 years there had been no one to urge them on. In 1893 the Government issued an order, and although the people of this community regarded it as an inscription carved in stone, it came to nothing. It was after this that, in 1893, I published the journal *Paraiyan* as a goad.

For my service in being the first to arise and labour among the millions who lie helpless and in distress in this Presidency, the Government have been pleased to confer on me the title of Rao Sahib on 1 January 1926, the title of Rao Bahadur on 3 June 1930, and the title of Diwan Bahadur on 1 January 1936.

> **TN 3.** "120 years" here and "121 years" in the chapter on Education both count from 1772 to 1893 (121 years).

The Journal, 1893

He who recites the great mantra "I! I!!" comes to know himself, becomes a sage who knows all, and beholds the Lord. In the same way, whoever says "I! I!!" — without disowning himself or his people, without fear or shame, speaking the truth and asserting his freedom — will be respected and will live in prosperity and lasting peace in his household life. But unless a man of the Paraiyar people comes forward and says, "I am the one called Paraiyan," he cannot assert his freedom: he will be kept down and will remain poor for ever. So I published a journal and crowned it with the title *Paraiyan*. It came out in October 1893. It was a small monthly of four pages, priced at two

annas a copy. When my caste-people, called Paraiyar, saw it, they welcomed it with great eagerness.

The advertising and the printing of the first issue cost ten rupees. Within two days about four hundred copies were sold within the city of Madras. After three months it became a weekly, and after two years it acquired its own printing press. The journal spoke up for the people called Paraiyar, sought the favour of the Government, and discussed good conduct and customs. Wherever these people gathered, they spoke with enthusiasm. To prove that they too were a community, on the evening of 7 October 1895 they entered the great Victoria Hall in Madras in a large procession, carrying white flags, with band music. They proclaimed their worth and greatness and held the meeting with great splendour. That was the first time this people had ever assembled in the Victoria Hall.

Caste Hindus, from the village munsifs to those in the Collectors' offices, the Board of Revenue and the other departments, played many intrigues. Congressmen, caste Hindus, religious-conversion propagandists, and even one faction within this people stood against us. They brought out a rival journal, and some other journals attacked us strongly. One man of this community went and lodged a complaint that I was about to flee the country, and tried to have me arrested on a warrant and disgraced. That did not succeed. In 1896, because I had published in *Paraiyan* something defamatory written by a correspondent, a section of this community dragged me to court. The people of this community came to the court in a great crowd. They wore the emblem "Paraiyar" on their turbans and on their breasts, and came to the court carrying purses of money. A fine of one hundred rupees was imposed; I do not know who paid it. They showed openly the attachment and love they held for their own people. From this it will be clear that the journal *Paraiyan* was the root cause of this people's mouths being opened, of their coming forward, and of associations and the community being formed.

When I set out for London for the advancement of this people, no one could be found fit to run the journal, so its publication was stopped. The journal had run continuously for seven years. Because this movement spread throughout India, many millions of people are now advancing.

[The Journey Abroad]

I meant to go to London, set out the hardships of the depressed, and seek the sympathy of the British. When I reached Bombay, my father sent me a telegram asking me to come back. Resolved that "a corpse that has gone to the burning-ground does not return", I took the first ship I could find sailing west, and reached the island called Zanzibar in East Africa. I stayed there two years, collected money, and went on by way of South Africa. I landed at the port called Delagoa Bay. Within the week that I waited there for a passport I came down with shivering fever (malaria). The doctors said I must either spend six months at sea in the sea air or go to a very cold hill country, and that if I returned to India it would be death.

While I lay ill, a washerman (*vannan*) of my own people and his good wife gave me the treatment I needed and looked after me. A rich gentleman there also took me in and cared for me. Leaving that place, I reached the port of Durban in the province of Natal. There too a man named Antony H. Peter looked after me, sent me to a very cold hill region, and helped me to obtain government employment. I cannot forget my gratitude to these three.

In the town called Verulam in Natal there was a man named Murugan, a big farmer and a wealthy man. He said that it was in me that he had found the worthiness of a Brahmin. He pressed me to accept a gift of a cow (*godanam*) and asked for my blessing. The good I had done for poor people came back to me, "as the coconut palm gives water from its own head". It took many years in that country for my illness to be cured. For the sake of my family's security I returned to my motherland. When I returned, though I rejoiced to see my children, my heart could not bear to see the unfortunate condition of my people.

> **TN 4.** "தெங்கு தன் தலையால் நீர் தருவது போல" is a proverb (Moothurai/Avvaiyar): the coconut, watered at its foot, repays with sweet water from its head. That is, a good deed is returned many times over. The *Writing Caste* English calls Murugan "a soothsayer and healer", but the Tamil says he was "a big cultivator and a wealthy man" (பெரிய பயிர்க்குடியானவராகவும் தனவந்தராகவும்).

I thought: the corpse that went to the burning-ground and came back has come to life again — perhaps God will yet bring me to London and fulfil my purpose. After I reached Madras, within a few years of the Government nominating me as a member of the Legislative Council, the Government sent me to London as a representative of the depressed classes to the Round Table Conference. I went there twice, and secured the national freedom and other rights needed by the depressed classes, not only in the Madras Presidency but throughout India. That the purpose I had held for twenty years, of going to London, was fulfilled is the good fortune my people have gained.

The Community

When the Aryans came and settled in our country and created the rules of caste, the Dravidas now called Paraiyar, Panchamar or Adi Dravidar did not consent. Enduring many hardships, they formed their own separate villages, called *cheri*, and lived as a separate community in the villages. They had their own temple, tank, guru, village headman (*nattanmaikkarar*), panchayat, washerman, barber, cremation ground and burial ground, widow-remarriage and divorce. The custom of those called *Desayi Chetti*, who extorted money on the pretext of settling disputes among them, is now dying out; I have condemned it. These people did not come forward openly and assert their rights; they fell under the Aryan rules of caste, and [the caste Hindus] kept them suppressed.

I tried to bring them together into one large community, so that they might claim their rights and enjoy them. Learning of the matters published in the journal, the people of this community held meetings all over the country and spoke about their hardships and their advancement. In Madras a central body called the "Paraiyar" Mahajana Sabha was established. I myself was its secretary and ran it.

In the year 1895 an event occurred. The Civil Service examination was being held in London. Those who passed it were Englishmen, and it was they who governed the country as Collectors, Judges and in the other responsible high offices of administration. The Congressmen submitted a bill in the British Parliament that this examination should be held in India as well. The Paraiyar Mahajana Sabha feared that if the examination were held in India too, caste Hindus would occupy the high offices and torment the poor castes as "untouchables". So on 23 December 1893 they held a large meeting in the hall of the Wesleyan Mission College, Madras, and opposed the bill. They collected 3,412 signatures on a petition 112 feet long and had it presented by a Member of Parliament, General Sir George Chesney. When they saw it, the Congressmen withdrew their

petition. After that, the Secretary of State for India ordered that persons of merit from the lower grades of service might be appointed to the higher posts. For the counter-petition, see Appendix 1.

> **TN 5.** The chronology is as in the Tamil: "an event in 1895", a meeting on 23 December 1893, and (in the chapter on the Congress) "the bill of 1894". The House of Commons resolution for simultaneous examinations was passed in June 1893. The protest petition must therefore date from late 1893 or early 1894.

The petition set out plainly the condition of the cultivators of this community in the villages. It also stated that even in the city of Madras, in Mylapore, in the Brahmin street near the house of an Indian who was a High Court Judge, there stood a notice-board saying "Paraiyar must not enter", and that Pachaiyappa's College, founded by caste Hindus, did not admit the children of this community. It was this petition that caused the board to be removed, and the college, after some time, to admit the children.

The Establishment of the Labour Commissioner

This came about as a result of the above petition.

Copies of the petition were given to every Member of Parliament. As a result, all the newspapers in England wrote about how cruelly caste Hindus treated many millions of agricultural labourers. An agitation arose: with such cruelty spread throughout India, how could the Government of India not attend to it? The Secretary of State for India pressed the Government of India to take action, and as a result the Government of India began consulting with the Government of Madras. After many years had passed in this way, they decided to raise the oppressed through education and economic betterment. They would appoint as Protector a member of the Civil Service senior in age and rank and of long experience, give him an establishment, and so advance these oppressed people. From that time the oppressed have been obtaining schools, house-sites, agricultural land and so on. When it was decided that the Protector and his establishment, created for the advancement of this people, should also look after artisans and labourers, he came to be called the Labour Commissioner.

I had asked the Government to grant *darkhast* land (assignable government waste land) in Chengalpattu district to the people of this community. They replied that there was not a single acre in that district to give them. On 28 April 1894, the Collector, Mr. Atkinson (*Atkinson Durai*), stated that the necessary land was available in Krishna district. But without financial help the poor could not go so far and cultivate it. Now we see thousands of acres being granted, and poor Adi Dravida cultivators applying directly to the Collector by *darkhast* and obtaining land. In education too the Labour Commissioner gives much help. Are not the favours the Government now bestows on these people due to the Paraiyar Mahajana Sabha's opposition to the Civil Service examination, which brought to light the harsh cruelty suffered by those called untouchables? Even while I was away from India, the Paraiyar Mahajana Sabha, united and as individual members, laboured with great effort. Even now I see some who do not join with their own people.

> **TN 6.** The Madras Labour Department under a Commissioner of Labour was set up around 1919–20 (I have not checked the exact date), and it took over the work of protecting the depressed classes. That it

> grew out of the 1893–94 petition is the author's own claim. ## How the Adi Dravida Community Came to Be Established

When Lord Elgin, Viceroy and Governor-General, visited Madras on 6 December 1895, [we] resolved to establish the Paraiyar community [publicly]. At the place where General Patters Road meets Mount Road in Madras, a long *pandal* (decorated canopy) was put up across the broad Mount Road and adorned. In its centre, on both sides, letters like gold were fixed, reading "The Paraiyar Mahajana Sabha welcomes His Excellency Lord Elgin and Her Ladyship". Planted British flags waved in the wind, calling "Welcome! Welcome!" The representative of the Crown of India and the chief gentlemen entered beneath it and passed on in their carriages. The people of this community watched with delight and celebrated with pride. At night too there were illuminations.

Having obtained permission to present an address of welcome to the Governor-General, I, as secretary, took the President of the Mahajana Sabha and six members to Government House. On the way one of us made a suggestion: that we might also take along a certain wealthy gentleman of this community. We agreed and went, but when we met that gentleman he delayed, talked back and forth, and did not come. Because of this we were half an hour past the appointed time. Not finding us, the servants were searching around the building, thinking that we were afraid to enter Government House and must be standing about somewhere. We drove straight to the front of the building, got down from our carriages and went in. The Chief Secretary had this doubt because no one of this community had ever entered Government House before.

There Anglo-Indians, Muhammadans and Christians stood waiting in groups of eight. We too stood together as a group. The other communities, on seeing us, appeared to be filled with dislike and anger. Lord Elgin recognised us as a community on an equal footing with them and spoke fitting, gracious words of goodwill. From that day the Paraiyar were recognised as a separate community, distinct from the Hindu community. Since then the Viceroys and Governors have recognised and treated them as a separate community.

In 1898, at the celebration of the sixtieth year of the reign of Her Majesty the Queen, Empress of India, we sent an address of congratulation. The Secretary of State for India wrote on 11 June 1898 that the Queen had accepted it with great pleasure. Like the three communities mentioned above, the community that has been called by many names (Paraiyar, Panchamar, the Depressed) and is now known as Adi Dravidar has gained the right, like other communities, to share in executive government, in administration, and in ministerial office. They now become members of the Legislative Councils, municipalities, local boards, panchayats and other bodies, high officers in the Civil Service, ministers and mayors, and they are advancing in education and wealth. The root cause of all this is that I gathered these people together and established them as an important community.

The great assembly (*Mahasabha*) of this community has continued without a break. Its name was changed to suit the times. Gentlemen of this community now run it as the Madras Provincial Depressed Classes Federation and the Scheduled Castes Party, and they have elected me its president.

Even today caste Hindus continue to torment the people of this community. For some years now the Civil Service examination has also been held in India. Because young men of our community have now reached the ability to be candidates in that examination, holding it in India is no longer opposed. When I perform my daily religious observances, I think of the unfortunate condition of

my people and pray to God to be gracious, so that they may advance and prosper. Those who toil to raise up their community will, generation after generation, possess every kind of wealth.

> **TN 7.** “இராஜ பிரதிநிதியும் கவர்னர் ஜெனரலுமான எல்ஜின் பிரபு... இந்திய அரசர் மற்றும் பிரதான கனவான்கள்”: I take “இந்திய அரசர்” here to mean the Viceroy as the King’s representative. It could also mean Indian princes. The three communities “mentioned above” are the Anglo-Indians, Muslims and Christians present at Government House.

Education

The Government, considering that if this community, depressed, poor and ignorant, was to be raised, education must be spread among them, issued an order, G.O. 68 of 1893. It may truly be called an inscription in stone. It laid down that if at least seven children enrolled, the Government should recognise the class as a school and give it a grant, and it contained many other favourable rules. But caste Hindus did not come forward to teach the untouchables, and the untouchables could not find teachers from their own people. In the city of Madras, the schools that various bodies had founded for religious conversion were unwilling to admit the children of this community on those terms, because the Government order did not suit them. So the Government order came to nothing within the city of Madras.

I reported this unfortunate situation to the Government on 21 October 1898. As a result of my representation, the Government ordered the Madras Municipality to establish schools. Day by day the people of this community have begun to succeed in higher education.

If one examines the Government records, one finds that from 1772 the Government had concerned itself with this community. In those days there was correspondence between Parliament and our Government, and many things were done for the cultivators of our community. In 1818 the Board of Revenue enquired of the Collectors about the condition of our cultivators. Then somehow it was neglected, until in 1893 the Government set about providing education. Even then the Government’s effort failed. The reason is that the officials, from the village munsif up through the revenue inspectors, tahsildars, deputy collectors and collectors to the Board of Revenue, were kinsmen of the caste Hindus, and many of them held land. These caste Hindus worked subtle intrigues so that the cultivators of this community should not advance.

So that our people should never again be left, as for 121 years, with no one to urge them on, and so that we should toil unceasingly and persistently to spread education among them, I published the journal *Paraiyan* in that same year, 1893. It became a goad. Through the Labour Commissioner and the Director [of Public Instruction], the Government now spends twenty or thirty lakhs of rupees every year to provide education. Those who receive [benefits] in the name of this community should enjoy them themselves and also help their own people; they must raise up the community. Education is the chief cause of progress.

For ten years I have been a member of the Senate of the University of Madras, guarding the advancement of the Adi Dravidas with eye and mind.

The Legislative Council

Within three months of joining the Legislative Council, I moved a resolution before the House, and the House accepted it unanimously. It was that it is the policy of the Government that members of the depressed classes may use public roads, wells, public buildings, markets and the like.

Intending to make a beginning towards prohibition, I moved a resolution in the Legislative Council that liquor shops should be closed one day a week, on Sundays, and on festival days and Government holidays. The House accepted it. For a few months only the liquor shops were kept closed on Sundays. Then the Government, saying that excise revenue was falling, opened the shops again as usual.

I brought a bill on documents signed by illiterate people. When common people who cannot read or write have to put their thumb-mark or finger-print on documents, the contents of the document should be read out clearly before a tahsildar or a similarly responsible officer and before witnesses. Only then should they put their thumb-mark or finger-print; the witnesses should sign, and the responsible officer should also sign to complete the document. Documents thumb-marked before village munsifs and karnams (accountants) should not be valid. The Government did not accept it.

I moved a resolution that the Government should not appoint munsifs, karnams and similar officers on a hereditary basis. The officers concerned in this Presidency held meetings and opposed it very strongly. That resolution has not yet come before the Council.

I not only had the law and the practice abolished of putting accused persons in the stocks (*thozhuvam*) in the village munsifs' courts, but I also had the stocks burnt.

A resolution was brought before the House that the salt tax should be abolished altogether. I opposed it. I argued that because the price of salt is very low, the tax causes the poor no hardship, and that with the revenue the Government receives from it, good could be done for the poor. The tax was not abolished. Because it was not abolished, there was an arrangement by which the Government of India was to give the Government of Madras more than ten lakhs. I had thought the Government would give it to the Adi Dravidas. The Government used it for another purpose.

A resolution was brought to reduce the land tax. I attacked it strongly. The landlords hold extensive lands, more than they can cultivate. When poor cultivators then apply for Government land to cultivate and live by, the landlords raise all kinds of objections: that it is a water-catchment, a pasture, a cattle-track, the place where the cattle gather at Pongal, the place where a stone is set up and the boundary-goddess (*Ellai Pidari*) is worshipped. They do not even pay the agricultural labourers their wage of two annas a day properly. They are rich, educate their children, make them high officials, live in upper-storeyed houses and drive about in motor cars in comfort. I argued that it could not in any way be accepted that such people are unable to pay land tax. The tax was not reduced.

I sat on many committees of the House, and I spoke there on many matters. I have also given evidence before many commissions.

The honourable members of the depressed communities in the Legislative Council chose me as the leader of their group. I sat in the Legislative Council for fifteen years. Now, in the present legislature, I have been nominated to the upper house, the Legislative Council, and I sit there.

> **TN 8.** The road-and-wells resolution probably dates from 1924 (not verified) (see Appendix 2 in the original, a Government Order). "The present legislature" is the bicameral legislature of 1937 under the Government of India Act, 1935: an Assembly and a Council.

Customs and Usages

As this history is about to go to print, Rao Bahadur M. C. Rajah has brought a bill to root out the habits, customs and *mamool* (established practices) by which caste Hindus afflict the Adi Dravidas with many hardships. Both houses of the legislature have passed it. This Act, and the Temple Entry Act for the district of British Malabar, are like toothless snakes. Anyone wronged under them, it seems, must file a suit in the civil court against those who violate them. If the people of this community protect these Acts, and the caste Hindus do not starve them to death, their teeth will grow in a few days.

> **TN 9.** M. C. Rajah's bill became the Madras Removal of Civil Disabilities Act, 1938. The Malabar Temple Entry Act was passed in 1938 (also 1939 in some sources).

The Round Table Conference

The Government chose and invited me and Dr. Ambedkar, as representatives of the depressed classes in India, to the all-party assembly called the Round Table Conference. The two of us worked together "like nail and flesh". We both attended the Conference held in the years 1928–1929. In 1930 the Doctor alone went to the Conference. They invited me to the Viceroy's Consultative Committee to seek my advice. The people of these communities in India were granted separate electorates and the franchise on terms more favourable than [those given to] other communities. The depressed classes will come to know the results of this in the next two or three elections.

> **TN 10.** The dates are as in the Tamil, but are wrong: the first and second Round Table Conferences, which Srinivasan attended, were held in 1930–31 and 1931. The third, in 1932, was attended by Ambedkar without him. The author (or the printer) appears to have shifted the dates.

In a few days the depressed will become the elevated, become a very strong community, and even reach the point of taking power. Knowing this, the caste Hindus are agitating for "temple entry" and for "abolishing untouchability", so that the depressed may join with them and not separate from them to become a large separate community.

I shall briefly tell only one or two incidents that happened while the Conference was in session. The Indian delegates attending the Conference were invited to the royal residence called Windsor Castle to meet King George and the Queen. The Emperor and Empress shook hands with me too and received me graciously. This happened three times. Refreshments were also served in the palace. Once more I had occasion to converse with the King. The King asked what untouchability meant. When I said that a man called "high caste" will not touch a man called "low caste", the King asked further: "If a low-caste man falls in the street, will the high-caste man not lift him up?" When I said that he would not, the King started, stood back, and said, "I will never allow that to happen in my kingdom." Was it not good fortune for our community that I could enter the King's palace and shake hands and speak with the King? Because the King treated us as equal with other communities, it is clear how loving and precious English rule is, and how it has helped our people to advance.

When the depressed classes opposed holding the Civil Service examination in India, and the matter was being debated, Mr. Eardley Norton, who was on the side of the Congress, said mockingly that I, a depressed man, was a candidate who wanted to go from a hut in a hamlet called Paddington to the royal palace called St James's. The Round Table Conference was held in St James's Palace itself. One day, as I sat in a great hall of that palace, what Mr. Norton had said came back to my mind. I smiled, and rejoiced that all that happens for the sake of poor people is the work of God.

When I came back to India, I explained what had been done at the Conference for this people, by publishing it at my own expense and by holding many meetings.

(The New Reform) The Poona Pact

After this Pact, the provincial legislature in Madras was constituted with an upper house called the Council and a lower house called the Assembly.

Joint Electorate

In the Assembly, the parties of other communities tried to win the members of the depressed classes to their side. The 30 members elected to the Assembly did not form a separate party: 27 of them joined the Congress party. Many people of this community may think this is the harm done by the joint electorate. They may not see that both the voters who elected these men and the elected members themselves have been acting either without heeding or without knowing what service to their community means and what results follow from it. The cause must be taken to be ignorance or poverty. For those reasons, harm will follow not only from the joint electorate but from the separate electorate as well.

Separate Electorate

When the Corporation election was held this past November 1938, those who stood as candidates for the seats reserved in separate constituencies for the Adi Dravida community declared that they stood for other communities and other parties. The Adi Dravida voters consented and supported them. From this it appears that in this city even those who have education, some wealth, discernment and a good knowledge of electoral matters slighted their own community and supported other communities and other parties. For the fault the community commits, shall I blame those who made the Poona Pact? If one looks at the history of the country and the history of the Adi Dravida community, the ten years laid down in the Pact will fly past like ten seconds.

My colleague Ambedkar and I took all necessary pains at the Round Table Conference and had the franchise qualification for this community made very easy. Of the 30 men who became members of the Legislature through this people's votes, 27 are sacrificing their votes to other parties, and it pains my heart to see this community take no notice. Those who do service to the community are those who labour so that their descendants may flourish.

> **TN 11.** "The ten years laid down in the Pact": the Poona Pact (clause 6) provided that the system of reserved seats would continue until ended by mutual agreement, and that the primary-election system would end after ten years. "Shall I blame those who made the Poona Pact?" renders "பூனா ஒப்பந்தம்

> செய்தோரை நிந்திப்பேன்", literally "I shall blame those who made the Poona Pact". The literal reading does not fit the context, since he was a signatory himself, so I read it as a rhetorical question [?].

Temple Entry

Caste Hindus have realised that as long as untouchability remains in India, full *swaraj* is not possible. So, through the Government, the caste Hindus put their movement into the form of a bill called "Temple Entry", to admit the untouchables into temples, and both houses of the legislature have approved it and made it law. That Act sets out the procedures to be followed to allow the Hindus called untouchables to enter Hindu temples in the district of British Malabar. It seems it will come into force very soon.

I have stated, in the journal *Paraiyan* and recently in pamphlets, that many important temples were built at the places where great men of the Adi Dravida community were cremated. Into the temples of the Adi Dravidas, people of all castes and creeds, Brahmins first, may enter and worship. But into the temples of the caste Hindus, no one may enter except the four castes contained among themselves.

If the caste Hindus open their temples to the Adi Dravidas, those who wish may enter. Let the caste Hindus consult among themselves and decide to open their temples. I have discussed this at length in a pamphlet called "Temple Entry".

Last year, when a section of the Hindus held a meeting in Madras to uphold *Sanatana Dharma*, I published and distributed a pamphlet. In it I asked whether it is *dharma* to have done the following: - renamed Sambava Samban of Tiruchirappalli as Jambukesvarar, Pravidai Samban of Thanjavur as Brihadisvarar, and Thiyaga Samban of Tiruvarur as Thiyagaraja Perumal; - seized the shrines built at the places where they were cremated, and usurped their rights in grants (*maniyam*), treasure and so on; - and moreover kept the Sambava descendants out, not allowing them to enter those shrines.

Conversion

When Dr. Ambedkar publicly declared that the depressed classes should change their religion to escape from the Hindu fold, I at once declared by telegram that the depressed classes are not within the Hindu fold, and that they should advance with manly courage while remaining in the religion they are in. It is obvious that the depressed are not within the Hindu fold, since they do not belong to any one of the four varnas that the Hindus observe.

Buddhism. In 1882 I met Madame Blavatsky and Colonel Olcott in the Nilgiris and kept company with them for some days. I joined the society of yogic experience [the Theosophical Society] and received initiation (*diksha*) from its president, Colonel Olcott. He used to speak in praise of Buddhism. In 1900 he began to introduce that religion into the depressed community. Fearing that it would cause division in the community, I attacked him through the journal. Each of us argued with the other as a "self-appointed lord" [?]. Some entered that religion. They said that "Buddhist" was a more honourable name than "Paraiyar". In some places they built monasteries. The help that the Government had arranged to give in education and economic matters to the community

called Paraiyar or Adi Dravidar ceased to be available to those of the community who became Buddhists.

> **TN 12.** "தான் தோன்றிய தம்பிரான்" is a Tamil idiom for a self-made authority who answers to no one. The sense is that each accused the other of arrogating authority. The words "in 1900" sit oddly with Srinivasan's departure for Africa in 1900 and the end of *Paraiyan*. Olcott's Buddhist schools for Paraiyar children began in 1894–98. I keep the author's date. The Buddhist movement in question is that of Pandit C. Iyothee Thass (Sakya Buddhist Society, 1898).

The caste Hindus called Hindu religionists and the depressed, who are Tamil religionists, belong to the same religious affiliation. Unable to bear the cruelty that caste Hindus inflict, the depressed change their religion. In response to the depressed classes' appeals over many centuries to be raised from their unfortunate state, the Government has for many years helped them to advance in education and wealth. Those who have left the depressed community by conversion and joined another community have raised a captious argument before the Government that they should be included with the depressed and helped. Under the Government's law, the boundaries of communities are fixed. The help the Government gives to one community should not be obtained by those of another religion.

If one changes from one religion to another, one has changed from one community to another. Such persons should not, from within the community they have joined, receive the help given to the community they were in before. If they are allowed to, the converts will take the whole of the help. Moreover, the depressed community fears that this will become a stratagem for converting them. It is best that those who have converted and joined another community should obtain separately from the Government the help they need. With this view I have spoken many times in the Legislature and written to the newspapers.

> **TN 13.** "Tamil religionists" (தமிழ் சமயிகள்) is the author's term. He distinguishes the religion of the depressed from that of the caste Hindus, while saying they share a common religious affiliation. His argument against extending depressed-class benefits to converts was a live issue in Madras politics in the 1930s. It reflects his position, not the translator's.

The Indian Congress

In 1884 the annual festival of the Theosophical Society, the society of yogic experience and wisdom, was held at the place called Adyar in Madras. I too was a member of the society. To that festival came Bengali babus, Parsis of Bombay, Brahmins of our Presidency, and many from Europe, America, Ceylon and other countries. I too went and joined them. Colonel Olcott was the president of the society. At that time the Bengali babus put forward an idea: that Indians might gather in the same way and hold an assembly on political matters. After they returned to Calcutta, the Indian Congress was formed in 1885. Colonel Olcott used to say of himself that he was the cause of the Congress coming into being.

Only the very rich and the very learned were in the Indian Congress and ran it. They talked and acted with the aim of seizing the government, but gave no thought whatever to the advancement of their own countrymen, the millions in India who are depressed and reduced to utter poverty. So dislike and opposition towards the Congressmen keep growing among the depressed. In 1894 the

depressed opposed, and defeated, the bill that the Congressmen took before Parliament for holding the Civil Service examination in India. For 45 years the depressed have been in dispute with the Congressmen.

From 1918, when Mr. Gandhi came forward, he and his supporters have agitated among the caste Hindus for twenty years to abolish untouchability. It is like rain falling in the forest. Mr. Gandhi stands as the master who instructs the Congress. The caste Hindus' tongues have turned to saying that untouchability must be abolished, but their hearts have not turned.

Some among the depressed say: "The demon called untouchability possesses the caste Hindus and makes them dance; they cannot drive it out themselves. If we take up the stick, we will drive it out of the country within a year. When strife is born, justice is born." I would say that strife leads to terrible suffering, and that it takes a very long time to recover from it. Enmity, hatred and arrogance are sinful. The way is to learn political strategy and to work towards the means of taking power. For that the Adi Dravida community must be made strong.

We see caste Hindus who are like the rams that rush into a fight, who squat and weep that the sheep is getting wet, and who leap into the flock to plunder it. These must be kept away, and those who betray the community for office and money must be set right. The Congressmen and the caste Hindus are running the government under the system of self-rule, and they are still striving to win full *swaraj*. Before they seize it, the Adi Dravidas must stand up in opposition, strengthen their community and resolutely reach the shore. It is my experience that the caste Hindus will not make way for the depressed until they realise that loss and hardship will come to themselves. We must support the community and do service to the community.

> **TN 14.** "ஆட்டுக்கடாக்கள் சண்டையில் புகுவதும், ஆடு நனைகிறதென்று குந்தி அழுவதும், மந்தையில் பாய்ந்து கொள்ளையாடுவதும்" combines Tamil proverbs. One is the fox that waits by the fighting rams for the blood. Another is "ஆடு நனைகிறதென்று ஓநாய் அழுததாம்" ("the wolf wept that the sheep was getting wet"), i.e. false sympathy. The sense is that caste Hindus feign concern while preying on the community. "Rain falling in the forest" means wasted effort, with no one to benefit.

Mr. Gandhi

Mr. Gandhi is always surrounded by the educated and the wealthy. I heard him lecture at Pachaiyappa's College in 1895–96, and in 1902 on the island of Zanzibar in East Africa. At a place called Phoenix in South Africa he was fasting, and I met him on the tenth and final day. He received me and showed me affection. From that day a friendship arose between us. That may have been in 1906. When he returned to India he agitated about untouchability. In 1920 I wrote an open letter [to him] and published it as a small booklet.

During the Round Table Conference I met him many times. He argued that he would not allow separate electorates to be given to the depressed even if it cost him his life. Separate electorates were given to the depressed. While he was in Yerwada jail at Poona, he began a fast unto death because separate electorates had been granted to the depressed. I saw him three times in the jail. I saw that, instead of arguing and winning, he had taken to fasting, and that he had lost his heroic spirit and had to seek pity. My heart was moved, and I signed the Poona Pact.

He often speaks of hearing an inner voice (*asariri*). I too have heard the inner voice; many have been blessed to hear it. I published in the press that one should not proclaim it. When he came to

Madras, I published our conversation as a small booklet. He collected many lakhs of rupees on behalf of the depressed and spent it on the education of their children. Though he agitated for many years to abolish untouchability, he could not peel fibre from the stony hearts of the caste Hindus. He calls the depressed “Harijans”, and he publishes a journal called *Harijan*. He writes in it whatever comes into his mind. One may say that most of it is not the opinion of the depressed. That is self-seeking. He is a good soul, blessed to hear the inner voice!

> **TN 15.** “கல்மனதினின்று நாருரிக்க” means literally “to strip fibre from a stone heart”, an idiom for an impossible task. The last sentence is, I think, gently ironic. The dates and places of his meetings with Gandhi are as the author gives them.

My Family Life

That I have stayed free of debt, and the gentle nature of my beloved wife, who never answered back, made it possible for me to work for the community. I have recorded this on her samadhi-stone in the Otteri burial ground, Madras.

Conclusion (*Mudivurai*)

When I began to publish the journal, aged elders who saw me blessed me, saying: “Son! The seed you have sown will be like the tamarind seed. It will take root, grow into a great tree, bend before the great storm-wind that beats against it with force, flourish and bear fruit. Other trees resist the storm, do not bend, and break and perish.”

As great waves strike one after another in a stormy sea, so the caste Hindus, the other communities, have struck at this community throughout the fifty years seen in this history. This community has bent before all those blows and has given no room to hatred, enmity or strife in the land. Loyal to the Crown, living as cultivators in the villages, they turn the soil and feed the people of the country. As their discernment grows they advance, and they have come to know the strength of the vote, the most important of the rights in the country. With the goad [?] in their hand, by their own effort they will also take up the sceptre, and flourish and rise high. May God grant that the people of this community grow strong in the time to come, as a good staff on which the nation may lean.

> **TN 16.** [?] “தாத்துக்கோல்”: I could not find this word. I read it as a form of “தார்க்கோல்”, the ox-goad of the ploughman, which fits the contrast with “செங்கோல்” (sceptre): the ploughman’s goad and the king’s sceptre. The reading is uncertain.

[Appendices — not translated]

The original contained: - **Appendix 1**: the counter-petition of the Paraiyar Mahajana Sabha (1893) against holding the Civil Service examination in India; - **Appendix 2**: the Government Order on the use of public roads, wells and so on by the depressed classes; - **Appendix 3**: the Poona Pact (1932).

I could not find the Tamil (or original) text of these appendices online. The *Writing Caste* blog gives only an English version, in Parts 14–15, and the archived copy of Part 15 breaks off. I have not reproduced or translated them. The Poona Pact itself is widely available in its official English text.